

News

Trump DOJ Hands Judge Unredacted Epstein Records After Katie Phang’s Court Win

The Justice Department now says it delivered the records directly to the judge after Katie Phang successfully challenged the government’s Epstein-file redactions.

Jul 30, 2026 3:50 PM EDT



By Brett Meiselas
Co-Founder of MeidasTouch



Add us on 



Composite using photo from REUTERS/Jonathan Ernst

Key Points

- Justice Department handed unredacted Epstein records to Judge Sullivan for private review.
- DOJ insists most redactions protect victims’ identities; admits mistakenly redacting Epstein’s email address.
- Judge Sullivan will decide if DOJ's redactions were justified after examining the documents himself.

M Trump DOJ Hands Judge Unredacted Epstein Records After Katie Phang's Court V
related records directly to a federal judge for private review, marking the latest
development in a lawsuit brought by attorney and MeidasTouch host Katie Phang
challenging the government's handling of the files.

In a new filing submitted July 30, Acting Attorney General Todd Blanche's Justice
Department notified U.S. District Judge Emmet Sullivan that it had complied with his July
25 order requiring the government to produce documents supporting a series of contested
redactions.

According to the filing, DOJ delivered hard copies of the documents by hand to Judge
Sullivan's chambers at 2:28 p.m. Thursday.

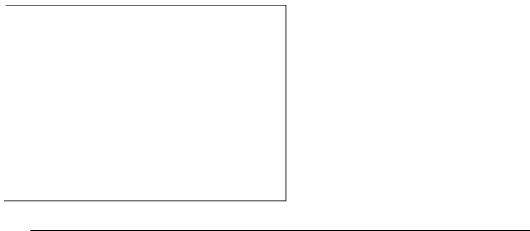
The records are being reviewed *in camera*, meaning privately by the judge rather than being
placed on the public docket. The step allows Sullivan himself to examine what the
government has concealed and determine whether DOJ's explanations for the redactions
hold up.

The Justice Department insists they do.

"The submitted documents show that the justifications cited in Defendant's briefing on this
issue support each redaction," government attorneys wrote.

The filing addresses 10 separate Epstein-file records identified by the court.

[SCRIBD]



View on Scribd

DOJ claims most of the disputed redactions conceal the identities of victims or potential victims, including individuals represented by attorneys who have asked the department to treat their clients as victims. Other redactions, the government says, protect personally identifiable information and the identities of law enforcement personnel and an Assistant U.S. Attorney.

But the filing also contains at least one notable admission.

DOJ says that after taking a closer look at one of the records, EFTA01187999, officials discovered they had “inadvertent[ly]” redacted Jeffrey Epstein’s own email address.

That redaction, the department says, “has since been lifted.”

The development comes after Sullivan ordered DOJ to provide the court with the unredacted material necessary to independently test the government’s claims about what it was withholding.

Phang’s lawsuit has challenged DOJ’s compliance with the Epstein Files Transparency Act and its decisions to keep information concealed from the public.

The dispute is particularly significant because the court is no longer being asked simply to take the Justice Department at its word. Sullivan now has the underlying documents in his

M Trump DOJ Hands Judge Unredacted Epstein Records After Katie Phang’s Court V actually redacted.

DOJ also used Thursday’s filing to say that some of the material remains covered by protective orders entered in the federal criminal cases against Epstein and Ghislaine Maxwell in the Southern District of New York.

Those orders, DOJ noted, prohibit the government from publicly disclosing the identities of individuals contained in discovery.

Protecting Epstein’s victims has not been the central point of dispute. Rather, Phang’s litigation has forced DOJ to substantiate whether the information it chose to hide actually falls within legitimate categories that may be withheld.

Thursday’s filing represents the government’s argument, not Judge Sullivan’s conclusion.

DOJ says its documents prove the redactions were justified. Sullivan will now have the opportunity to examine the unredacted records himself and determine whether he agrees.

And the government has already acknowledged that at least one redaction should not have been there in the first place.

The next major development could come when Sullivan rules on whether DOJ’s remaining redactions survive that scrutiny.

Pre-order the new book from MeidasTouch, WTF America?!: The Way Out of This Hell and Back to Democracy, today, by [clicking here](#).

About The Author



Brett Meiselas
Co-Founder of MeidasTouch

Trending Stories

J.D. Wolf

Voting to Block Release of the Files

Troy Matthews

03

News

U.S., North America Join Europe in Rejecting FIFA's Kushner Investment Deal

Troy Matthews

04

News

Michael Whatley Keeps Turning Up Alongside a Church at the Center of an Abuse Scandal

Aaron Parnas



NewsPodcastsVideoWatch

Site MapAbout UsContact UsEditorial PolicyPrivacy PolicyTerms of Use

Do Not Sell My Information / Privacy Settings